Pi & Planck

HISTORY OF SCIENCE

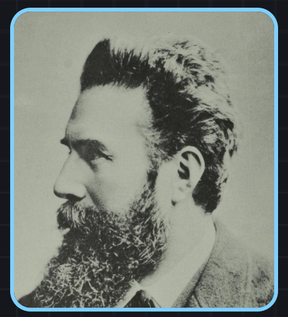
X-Rays: A Glow in a Dark Room

On 8 November 1895, Wilhelm Röntgen found rays nobody had seen. He called them X-rays.

THE MAN AND THE FIRST IMAGE



Anna Bertha Röntgen's hand, 22 Dec 1895



Wilhelm Conrad Röntgen

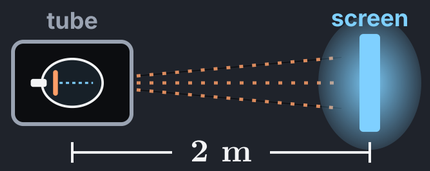
Professor of physics, Würzburg

Nobel Prize in Physics, 1901

FROM A GLOW TO A NOBEL PRIZE

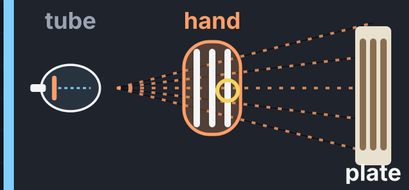


THE GLOW, 8 NOV



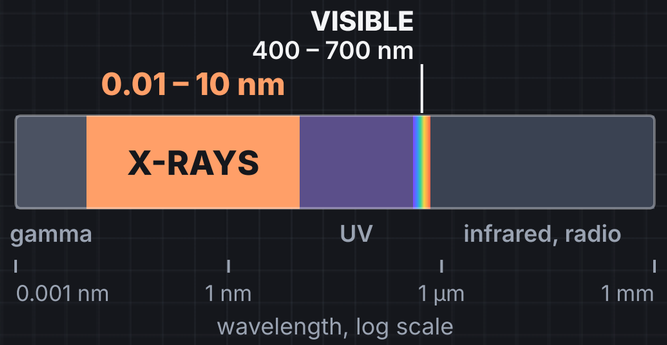
Tube sealed in black cardboard. The screen still glowed, even 2 m away.

THE HAND, 22 DEC



Bones stop more rays than flesh, so the plate records their shadow.

A NEW KIND OF RAY



Visible light has waves 40 to 70,000 times longer.

X Röntgen's name for the unknown. Later shown to be waves like light, only much shorter.

2 m How far from the tube a screen still glowed on the evening of 8 November 1895.

1/1 The first Nobel Prize in Physics, 1901, awarded to Röntgen alone.

0.01–10 Nanometers: the wavelength range of X-rays (NASA).

Sources: Nobel Prize Outreach (Röntgen, biographical and facts) · APS News, Nov 2001 · Röntgen, Sitzungsberichte Würzburg 1895 · Nature 53 (1896) · NASA Universe Glossary · Photos: 1895 radiograph (Wellcome Library, London) and 1890s portrait, public domain

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